

Rethinking the Colonial Generalities: Putting the Cod
and Cohesion in Their Places

Donald T. Smith
Indiana University

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HISTORY TEACHERS often make simple, mnemonic statements about the time periods they present. These mnemonic statements serve two purposes: as a summary statement about the period in question and as a pedagogical tool to convey its history. Several mnemonic summary statements in common use today concern the colonial period in American history. "From God to cod" has been used to describe how the Puritans proceeded from a preoccupation with religious matters to an occupation with matters economic. In emphasizing a slightly different aspect, "From cohesion to chaos" has been used to describe how the homogeneous Puritan community disintegrated within two or three generations into the heterogeneous New England society. And the reverse, "From chaos to cohesion," has been used to illustrate the transformation of the Chesapeake Bay region from a wild and woolly haven for adventurers to a stable and traditional agrarian aristocracy.

New England

Two strong proponents of the phrases "From God to cod" and "From cohesion to chaos" were Charles M. Andrews and Perry Miller. Andrews wrote three volumes, published in 1934, detailing the history of the colonial foundings, and a fourth companion volume discussing the economic and political relations between England and its American colonies.

Andrews' three volumes support those summary statements in a number of ways. The Plymouth Colony, for instance, was not established as a worldly business venture but as a settlement for the morally righteous. Andrews also suggested that the Massachusetts Bay Company was more than just a trading company as had been the London Company, the Bermuda Company, and the Virginia Company of Plymouth. In fact, the seat of the Massachusetts Bay Company was specified as the colony itself, thus signifying its intended break with England. Theirs was actually a holy experiment to renovate the church. Though Andrews acknowledged the secular roots of some Connecticut settlements and the colonies further south, he considered most of New England to have been colonized expressly for religious purposes. Still, Andrews would declare that, by the 1650s and '60s, "the heroic age of Puritanism had passed" as there was no longer a divorce between godly discipline and worldly happiness.' Enter chaos.

Of all the recent historians, Perry Miller would most subscribe to the "From God to cod" and "From cohesion to chaos" theses. The *New England Mind: The Seventeenth Century* explored in great detail the theological

workings of those early Massachusetts settlers' minds. His companion volume, *The New England Mind: From Colony to Province*, discussed how the second and third generations of those initial settlers turned the Founders' sectarian settlement toward more worldly pursuits. This theme of decline into chaos is so prominent that Miller divided *From Colony to Province* into four books: "Declension," "Con fusion," "The Splintering of Society" and "The Socialization of Piety." Further corroborating evidence for "From God to god" and "From cohesion to chaos" may be found in some other works. For instance, Bernard Bailyn, writing in the 1950s, believed that a growing merchant class gradually caused changes in the colony's religious, social, and political life until it finally gained control of the colony under the new Charter of 1691...

The Chesapeake

Practically all the evidence reviewed seems to confirm a progression from chaos to at least some degree of cohesion as an accurate description of the history of the Chesapeake Bay colonies. The first historian to posit the currently accepted view of Virginia's political history was Thomas J. Wertenbaker. In *Patrician and Plebeian*, published in 1910, and two subsequent volumes, Wertenbaker concluded that seventeenth-century Virginia was a yeoman democracy of small landowners, which was undermined before century's end by a planter class installed on the backs of slave labor. It was that planter class that finally brought stability and cohesion to the colony by both economic and physical force. A generation later, Louis B. Wright examined the libraries of Virginia's leading citizens of the seventeenth century and concluded that the ruling planter class had risen earlier than Wertenbaker had conjectured-not long after mid-century.

In the 1930s Charles M. Andrews recounted the deaths, the confusion, and the unchecked greed that pervaded the early years of Maryland, the other Chesapeake colony. Despite the presence of a Catholic enclave in the midst of the Protestant British colonies, Andrews made it clear that Maryland was not founded for religious reasons-it was, as was Virginia, strictly a business venture. Maryland, in fact, was established as a feudal state in which residents had to swear a loyalty oath to the proprietor. During the English Civil War, Maryland degenerated into utter chaos. Lord Leonard Calvert fled to Virginia and was later restored, with the help of Virginia's Governor Berkeley, following "the Plundering Time." Only after 1691, when the Third Lord Baltimore lost all rights to govern the colony (but not to own the land), did Maryland achieve a semblance of order. Andrews also recounted the early years of the two Carolina colonies, caught between nascent French and Spanish settlements and hostile Yamassee Indians. Neither colony's formative years were as deadly as Virginia's, but both were at least as chaotic as were their sister colonies to the north.

One event in seventeenth-century Virginia long thought to have shown budding colonial cohesion was Bacon's Rebellion. Wilcomb Washburn suggested, however, that the Rebellion was anything but concerted action by settlers fighting English tyranny; it was more like disgruntled frontiersmen showing their dislike for a tolerant colonial policy toward friendly Indians. One could maintain, in fact, that the level of maturity on the part of Governor Berkeley showed that the colony was heading toward just, cohesive governance.